ACADEMIA | Letters

Assimilating I and You/Other

Panayiota (Pollyn) Chrysochou

> '…for me to have not an idea, an image, nor a representation, but as it were the imminent experience of them, it suffices that I look at a landscape, that I speak of it with someone. Then, through the concordant operation of this body and my own, what I see passes into him…There is here no problem of the *alter ego* because it is not *I* who sees, because an anonymous visibility inhabits both of us, a vision in general, in virtue of that primordial property that belongs to the flesh, being here and now, of radiating everywhere and forever, being an individual, of being also a dimension and a universal.'
> (Maurice Merleau-Ponty, *The Visible and the Invisible*, p. 142)

What Merleau-Ponty so rightly illustrates in his ground-breaking work on vision and its dynamics is that the very question of seeing is not only intimately linked, in Kantian terms, to representation and perception but is also a bodily experience which is inscribed on the flesh.[1] Yet the very process of this inscription presupposes not just a viewing subject who *sees* (in the sense of either mentally perceiving an object or having it readily available to sight through physical and tangible representation) but also a viewing subject who can iterate, in the 'here and now', through what Julia Kristeva calls a *state of flesh*, what he sees to an other outside

[1] In Immanuel Kant's Existentialist metaphysics, the rupture which clearly exists between perception and representation, the perceived object as it is conceived in the mind and the way it is physically represented, can be bridged by a recourse to reason and experience. 'Our representation of things, as they are given, does not conform to these things as they are in themselves, but [that] these objects as appearances conform to our mode of representation,' in Immanuel Kant, *Critique of Pure Reason*. Qtd. in Marina Warner, *The Inner Eye: Art Beyond the Visible* (London: National Touring Exhibitions, 1996-7), p. 10.

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himself, the not-I which serves to moor the subject's scopic vision to the realm of concrete experience.[2]

Thus a two-fold process is ensured whereby the thing that is *seen* is also iterated in and through language, mediated through my flesh to 'pass into' the other. Yet even before this idea-image-representation passes through the semiotic system of signs, that is, before I can even begin to verbalize that which I see and hence enact a folding into the other's skin through my own body's "semiotic function", I need to be able to assimilate the concatenation of symbols which pass before my field of vision into a kind of semantic coherence.[3] This is precisely why sight itself has such mesmerising power; it antedates language and operates as an *a priori* given which navigates the realm of recognition. As John Berger aptly points out in *Ways of Seeing*, 'seeing comes before words. The child looks and recognizes before it can speak.'[4] Thus assimilation of the scopic field and recognition of its existence precede experiential knowledge that is acquired *via* recourse to a linguistic system.

Undoubtedly this field of vision itself encapsulates both the perceived object as it is mentally imaged and the physical object *per se* in all its materiality. That there is, to begin with, a split between the mental idea of an object and its physical representation in reality is not a novel idea. Plato, for example, postulates in his philosophical writings that material objects are merely imitations of a 'real' form or idea which is both abstract and transcendent, a form which breaks with spatio-temporal boundaries and subsists along the axis of representation as both a mental image and a pure archetype beyond the sphere of mental consciousness.[5] Certainly it is noteworthy that Plato's pupil Aristotle expounds on the faulty reasoning which is

[2]Qtd. in Julia Kristeva, 'Is Sensation a Language?', in *Writing and Psychoanalysis: A Reader*, ed. by John Lechte (London & New York: Arnold, 1996), p. 199.

[3]I use the term 'semantic function' here deliberately to depict the body's ability to function as a signifier or sign which is involved in and mediated through ontological discourse. The term is employed by Paul Youngquist, in 'Ballard's Crash-Body,' in *Postmodern Culture* 11:1 (September 2000), Internet:<http://muse.jhu.edu/journals/postmodern_culture/ toc/pmc11.1.html>. For an interpretation of how language functions as an ontological system, *see* Jacques Lacan, who points out in *Ecrits* in a chapter entitled 'Function and field of speech and language' that language is not an abstraction but a material body: 'language is not immaterial. It is a subtle body, but body it is' (p. 95). Jacques Lacan, 'Function and field of speech and language,' in *Ecrits: A Selection*, trans. by Alan Sheridan (London & New York: Routledge, 2003), pp. 33-125.

[4]John Berger et al., *Ways of Seeing: Based on the BBC television series with John Berger* (London: British Broadcasting Corporation, 1975), p. 7. This is certainly not to suggest that the auditory and tactile sense-perceptions which precede sight are of any less importance to the schematic development of the child's perceptual apparatus. While touch and hearing are of course significant, what primarily concerns me is the visual apparatus and its capacity to perceive material objects in the existential world.

[5]Most of Plato's work centres, in fact, on the question of the Idea. His Theory of Forms is posited at large in *The Republic* and *Symposium*, seminal works which, together with those of Aristotle, helped shape much of Western thinking and philosophy.

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implicit in the Platonic Idea, insofar as it manifests itself simply as a pure and transcendental entity that is divorced from individual sense-perception and anchored in a public domain of universals. Yet what interests me here is not so much whether the image can exist independently of the mind or the perceptual apparatus. Nor is it a question of whether the image functions as a concrete representation of some universal archetype or is subsumed under the realm of individual sensory experience and thus subsequent knowledge. To pose such a bipolarity would, in effect, be a disservice; all images can be detached from spatio-temporal contexts and relegated to some conceptual sphere of abstraction, yet this is not to say that these images cannot be brought to bear on an individual's sensory perception within the framework of a semantic field of experience.[6]

Hence, whereas it is undoubtedly the case that individual sense-perception precedes the universal or public domain of reality (either as abstract or concrete), it is the subsequent interaction of the individual with this domain which consolidates his knowledge of the outside world as constituted in and through ideas and representations. Thus one mode of reasoning leads on inevitably to the next in a coexistent series, and it is the constant interaction between these two modes which allows for what Merleau-Ponty defines as both 'a dimension and a universal.'

In terms of dimensional self-reflexivity, the visual image first inscribes itself as sense-perception in the mind's eye.The Neoplatonist alchemist Robert Fludd captures this idea by way of a diagram, in which an adult's mental consciousness is seen as a cinematic screen onto which visual images are projected. In Marina Warner, *The Inner Eye: Art Beyond the Visible*, p. 12. *See* note 1 above. As Simon Goldhill points out, this concern with self-reflexivity is certainly not a new concept; it can be traced as far back as the 5th century AD in Ancient Greece. The Greeks had established the connection between knowledge and sight through their common etymological derivation: 'Since in Greek the word "to know" (*eidenai*) is semantically and morphologically cognate with the word "to see" (*idein*), the "analytique du regard" is always already an anatomy of the subject's claim to know.'[7] Thus the visual image's sensory inscription in the mind always already assumes its assimilation and incorporation into consciousness. However, for the image to gain its full semantic impact, in other words, for

[6]In a similar vein, and in a line of thinking which seems to run parallel to that of Plato's, John Berger et al. note in *Ways of Seeing* that 'an image is a sight which has been recreated or reproduced. It is an appearance, or a set of appearances, which has been detached from the place and time in which it first made its appearance and preserved – for a few moments or a few centuries,' pp. 9-10. *See* note 4 above.

[7]Simon Goldhill, 'Refracting Classical Vision: Changing Cultures of Viewing,' in *Vision in Context: Historical and Contemporary Perspectives on Sight*, pp. 17-28 (20). *See* note 1 of the *Preface*. Of course this notion that knowledge is founded on sight is challenged by plays such as Sophocles' *Oedipus Rex*, a play which I shall explore in great depth in Chapter 2.

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the image to be fully able to cloak itself in invested meaning, it needs to be mediated through an-other's field of vision. As Berger aptly observes, 'soon after we can see, we are aware that we can also be seen. The eye of the other combines with our own eye to make it fully credible that we are part of the visible world.[8]

Yet since the mental image itself is only an imitation of its actual physical representation, it necessarily follows that what is incorporated or *internalized* within the mind's eye is only a referential and disembodied sign of the material image.[9] Thus on a scopic level, this schism between perception and representation creates an *a priori* fracture between the organic eye which sees and the mental eye which perceives. What is more, this fracturing of vision is further proliferated by the mediation of the eye of the other, which serves to split subjective markers of vision into supplementary fragments. This is always mediated through a discourse of desire. As Irit Rogoff notes, there are two critical traditions of the gaze. Whilst one is concerned with the gaze as an instrument in the investigation and validation of scientific and technological Western post-enlightenment processes, the other implicates desire and spectatorship through a mediated other. Thus 'the gaze as desire' divides 'spectatorship into the arena of desiring subjects and desired objects, a separation increasingly tempered by the slippages between the ever-eroding boundaries of exclusive objecthood and coherent subjecthood.'[10]

Paradoxically, however, it is through this divisive slippage or prismatic chaos of different visual markers that substantive meaning is created. Through the chain of non-linguistic signifiers which instantiate the mediation between self and other, object and idea, a unified and coherent narrative is formed which – although pre-linguistic at the outset – firmly and *a posteriori* roots itself in language. In other words, through the mediation of the other the I/eye is able to assimilate the fragmented signifiers into a cohesive whole and to give utterance to that which is seen. By assimilating the other into our own scopic field of consciousness, we can attempt to suture our own fragmented identity or to recreate coherent narratives of self. Such a project is clearly tenuous and *always already* out of reach. But we should always keep our eye towards the Other and attempt to assimilate it, embrace it, enfold it, keeping it firmly within our field of vision. It is only through attempting such an assimilation that we can achieve – or

[8] In *Ways of Seeing*, p. 9.

[9] Although my analysis is concerned with images that are rooted in a concrete materiality, it is clearly important to bear in mind that there are those images, more aptly defined as abstract symbols, which do not neatly conform to this mode of representation since they are always already, in and of themselves, disembodied.

[10] Irit Rogoff, "'Other's Others": Spectatorship and Difference,' in *Vision in Context*, pp. 189-202 (189).

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try to achieve – what Griselda Pollock calls 'new pleasures, a 'new language of desire."'[11]

[11]Qtd. in Rogoff: 'As Griselda Pollock says, "Neither veiled as enigma and mysterious other, nor punished by our foolish desire to 'assimilate' to the figures of power, we have to return a steady and resilient look at our culture. The game is not to strip away the veil and expose the truth – it is to know what masks we wear, to define the texts we perform and to accept the necessity for critical knowledge as the condition for new pleasures, a 'new language of desire"' (199).

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